
Paper 3, Option 39.1: Civil rights and race relations in the USA, 1850–2009

Overview

This option comprises two parts: the *Aspects in breadth* focus on long-term changes and contextualise the *Aspects in depth*, which focus in detail on key episodes.

Together, the breadth and depth topics explore developments that have shaped contemporary America and remain a fundamental issue in US society: the changing pattern of race relations between black and white Americans, both in terms of civil rights and also broader social and cultural changes over a period that began with millions of black Americans in slavery and ended with Barack Obama as President.

Aspects in breadth: changing perceptions of race relations, 1850–2009	
Themes	Content
1 The changing geography of civil rights issues	• The changing geographical distribution of black Americans, 1850–2009 (key developments: freedom in 1865, the slow drift north, the First Great Migration c1910–30, the Second Great Migration c1940–70, the migration back to the old south in the late twentieth century). • The changing pattern of settlement and segregation 1850–2009 (key developments: mass migration into Harlem from 1905; riots in Chicago 1919, Tulsa 1921, Watts 1965 and Newark 1967; developments in <i>de-facto</i> segregation in Levitt estates, white exodus to the suburbs post-1945 in the north; increasing de-segregation in the old south post-1970).
2 Changing portrayal of civil rights issues in fiction and film	• The role of literature in shaping and reflecting changing perceptions of race relations, 1850–2009 (key developments: the publication of <i>Uncle Tom's Cabin</i> 1852; <i>Huckleberry Finn</i> 1885, <i>Gone with the Wind</i> 1936, <i>To Kill a Mockingbird</i> 1960, <i>Beloved</i> 1987, <i>The Help</i> 2009). • The role of visual portrayals in influencing and reflecting changing perceptions of race, 1850–2009 (key developments: images of black Americans in paintings, photographs and lithographs 1850–80, <i>Birth of a Nation</i> 1915, <i>In the Heat of the Night</i> 1967, <i>Roots</i> 1977, <i>Mississippi Burning</i> 1988, <i>Malcolm X</i> 1992, <i>The Wire</i> 2002–08).

Aspects in depth: emancipation and moves towards greater equality	
Key topics	Content
1 'Free at last', 1865–77	- Reasons for, and importance of, the Thirteenth Amendment 1865: economic position of ex-slaves and the development of sharecropping; social tensions; the need for a political settlement; President Andrew Johnson's response. - Radical Reconstruction, 1867–77: the impact of military rule in the south; the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments; the Civil Rights Act 1875; significance of the presence of black representatives in federal and state legislatures. - The backlash: the Ku Klux Klan and White League, including the incidence of lynching; the restoration of Democrat control in the south and the end of Reconstruction 1877.
2 The triumph of 'Jim Crow', 1883–c1900	- Impact of the Civil Rights Cases 1883 in the Supreme Court. - The spread of Jim Crow Laws: changes to rail travel in Florida 1887; extension of segregation to other social areas and other states. Excluding black voters: discrimination in Mississippi from 1890; Louisiana's Grandfather clause 1898; impact on voter numbers in the south in the 1890s. - The impact of Plessy v. Ferguson 1896; Williams v. Mississippi 1898; Cumming v. Board of Education 1899.
3 The New Deal and race relations, 1933–41	- The influence of southern whites in the Democrat Party. - The failure to address black grievances: continuation of Jim Crow Laws, exclusion of black voters and the defeat of federal attempts at anti-lynching legislation. - Impact of the New Deal: effects of the AAA on black farmers; segregation in the CCC and differential wages in the NRA; benefits of welfare to black workers and their families; the work of Eleanor Roosevelt; impact on the voting patterns.
4 'I have a dream', 1954–68	- Civil rights activities, 1954–63: the role of Earl Warren and the Supreme Court; the impact of victory in Montgomery; the work and impact of Martin Luther King, SCLC, SNCC and CORE, 1957–63. - Civil rights 1964–68: the importance of the Civil Rights Acts 1964 and 1968, the Voting Rights Act 1965; the role of Lyndon Johnson. - Increasing divisions: the expulsion of whites from SNCC and CORE; the growth of the Black Panthers; the role of Malcolm X; King's stance on the Vietnam War, assassination and its immediate effects.
5 Obama's campaign for the presidency, 2004–09	- The importance of the political career of Barack Obama to 2006, including his election as senator for Illinois in 2004. - The reasons for his success in gaining the Democratic nomination for the presidency: personality and rhetorical abilities; the opposition; new election strategies; policies.